

Trump takes aim at the EU's Canada pitch

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【メール原文】

Presented by Altana By GERARDO FORTUNA CIAO THERE. It's Gerardo Fortuna, still in Strasbourg, a place where god and mortals trawl the same back alleys

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By GERARDO FORTUNA

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CIAO THERE. It's Gerardo Fortuna, still in Strasbourg, a place where god and mortals trawl the same back alleys in search of sustenance ...

SPOTTED ... strolling down one of those alleys just before 9:30 p.m., Bjoern Seibert, Ursula von der Leyen's powerful right-hand man, heading out for pizza after a long day ... week ... month ... preparing the European Commission chief's State of the Union address. Playbook asked Seibert how he was feeling after the big speech. Relieved it's over, he said.

WHILE YOU WERE SLEEPING: U.S. President Donald Trump threatened to impose "very heavy tariffs" if the European Union admits Canada as an associate member — warning that he could treat von der Leyen's audacious offer to Ottawa Wednesday as a "hostile act."

In a gaggle with reporters at an airport in North Carolina, Trump dismissed the prospect of Canada integrating with the bloc as "laughable," adding: "If I think it's at all a hostile act, I will put very serious tariffs or stop trading with Europe on many things." My colleagues in Washington have the full story .

DECODING AI: Amid the dire warnings about AI's future and calls for governments to act, there are precious few voices offering clarity on what should actually be done, by whom and where. That's why we're launching Decoded by POLITICO, a briefing on the people, power moves and policy fights shaping the AI era, drawing on nearly 50 journalists around the world.

We held our first Decoded Summit in Washington yesterday (read the highlights here), and more are planned in other key capitals in the months ahead. A new daily newsletter and audio podcast launch on Oct. 5. Sign up here .

In today's Playbook:

- António Costa is in Dublin to compare notes on the budget talks.
- While Canada gets a promise of associate membership, Kosovo is still stuck in the EU's waiting room.

— Faces in the crowd: Teresa Ribera, Gabriel Attal, Jeton Zulfaj, Wopke Hoekstra, Gaia Giorgio Fedi, René Repasi, Věra Jourová, Alberto Núñez Feijóo, Jonathan Wilkinson and many more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Sarah discuss why London is crying on the sidelines as Mark Carney takes the stage for his big speech to the European Parliament.

****A message from Altana:** Altana is the AI network where businesses, logistics providers, and governments are rearchitecting global trade. With Altana, businesses can prove compliance before goods ship and build more efficient, resilient, and secure supply chains. Logistics providers can automate the full brokerage workflow, and governments can promote economic security, manage borders, and enable the flow of trusted trade.**

DRIVING THE DAY

A MIXED BLESSING: The EU's burgeoning friendship with Canada was already getting complicated before Donald Trump crashed the party overnight.

First came the will-she-won't-she fuss over whether Commission President Ursula von der Leyen would attend Prime Minister Mark Carney's speech in the European Parliament today.

Then came yesterday's bombshell: von der Leyen's proposal for Canada to become an "associate member" of the EU. A draft of the speech obtained by POLITICO before von der Leyen took to the stage didn't contain the Canada line. And one diplomat said the version that capitals received didn't have it either.

Nobody seems entirely sure what an EU "associate member" is, since that status doesn't exist yet. "We're entering terra nova," Climate Commissioner Wopke Hoekstra said outside the chamber — which might have been a Canada joke, given that Terra Nova is the old name for Newfoundland. "We're entering the unknown," Hoekstra added.

Commission Executive Vice President Teresa Ribera conceded that the Canada move is first and foremost a declaration of intent — but called the idea "quite thrilling and interesting." But MEP and EU law professor René Repasi said doing it "properly" would require treaty change. A more realistic route, he suggested, could look more like the European Economic Area. (Sorry, Britain: Associate membership isn't on the cards in any post-Brexit reset.)

But here's the really awkward bit: The idea wasn't presented in advance to European capitals and even Ottawa seems to be distancing itself from the "associate" label, as Sebastian Starcevic and Max Grier report.

"We're not there," Jonathan Wilkinson, Canada's incoming ambassador to the EU, told reporters in Strasbourg when asked about associate membership. "What we're focused on is actually driving results."

Stuck in the middle with you: Von der Leyen's speech also floated the creation of a European Security Council that would bring together the leaders of Canada, the U.K., Norway and Ukraine. That's an extension of Carney's famed Davos speech in which he called for the world's "middle powers" to stand together against autocrats, as Nicholas Vinocur reports.

But the European Security Council would sit outside of NATO — which might cause a problem with the military alliance .

Cue the Carney-val: Von der Leyen's speech yesterday was reassuring — doctors won't be replaced by AI; housing is a right; Europe is less vulnerable to another energy crisis — but hardly a barnburner. The verdict among those Playbook spoke to in Strasbourg was that it was all rather flat. Expectations are higher for Carney's address today. One MEP from von der Leyen's own political family said it could make the Commission chief's unconvincing performance look even worse.

Stay tuned: Carney is due to speak in the European Parliament at 11:30 a.m. Watch it here and follow on our live blog .

BIG AND BREAKING

SWEDISH ELECTION UPDATE: Social Democratic Party leader Magdalena Andersson is on course to become prime minister , with her center-left bloc now holding an unassailable lead after 99.9% of results were declared.

RUSSIA SANCTIONS: The U.S. House passed the sweeping Russia sanctions bill championed by the late Sen. Lindsey Graham overnight, giving Washington more tools to squeeze Moscow — but Democrats worry a tariff provision could be turned against America's allies.

RATE HIKE: The Federal Reserve has lifted official U.S. interest rates for the first time in three years — and hinted there might be more to come — in an early test of the relationship between new Chair Kevin Warsh and Donald Trump.

GETTING READY: European People's Party chief Manfred Weber told colleagues on Tuesday that he'll run for reelection and asked for their support ... and announced that he's set up a task force ("Win 2029") to map out the group's strategy to confront the far right in the next European Parliament election, according to a document seen by POLITICO.

COSTA ON TOUR

COSTA'S BIG BUDGET DEBRIEF: European Council President António Costa is in Dublin today to debrief Irish Taoiseach Micheál Martin on his tour of EU capitals.

Costa has visited 24 leaders to bring them closer to an agreement over the EU's next seven-year budget before an informal end-of-year deadline. His input will be crucial for Ireland, which holds the rotating presidency of the Council of the EU and plays a key role in steering the discussions.

Dublin will put forward a new negotiating document, or negobox, with revised figures that will set the tone for a leaders' meeting on Oct. 15, which will last for two days and touch on other issues including competitiveness, enlargement and Ukraine.

Appetizer: After making it to Dublin on a delayed Ryanair flight, Costa will share with Martin the findings of his meetings to help him strike the right balance in the negobox. The taoiseach has been carrying out his own budget consultations, including a call with French President Emmanuel Macron and a meeting with the Visegrád Group.

“It will be a moment to compare notes and chart the way for the October European Council,” said an EU official. Costa’s priority is to narrow down which EU-wide taxes — or own resources — could finance the budget with strong backing among countries.

Costa won’t find encouragement from a heated discussion on the size of the budget among the EU’s 27 ambassadors on Wednesday, which was “the most useless session so far,” according to one EU diplomat. “It was smoke and mirrors,” said a second diplomat, adding that countries caused confusion by using different metrics to calculate their budget contributions.

With friends like these: Germany renewed calls to slash the budget by hundreds of billions of euros — warning that otherwise there will be no deal by the end of the year, and EU payouts will be delayed after 2028, said one of the diplomats. France retorted that this would lead to the expiry of Germany’s discount on budget contributions, better known as a rebate.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

How close are Canada and the EU? Well, there’s a trade agreement (the EU-Canada Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement, or CETA) and trade in goods and services between the two sides was €130 billion in 2025. There’s also the EU-Canada Strategic Partnership Agreement, which covers the likes of human rights, economic and sustainable development, and justice.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked what you think about Canada becoming an associate member of the EU. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

KOSOVO WAITS

A BIG LETDOWN: While Canada got a song and dance about associate membership, the countries that have been in the EU’s waiting room for years got nothing concrete from von der Leyen’s big speech yesterday.

And they’re feeling forgotten. Playbook’s Zoya Sheftalovich spoke with Jeton Zulfaj, Kosovo’s chief negotiator with the EU, who lamented that four years after officially applying to join the bloc, Kosovo hasn’t even received candidate status. “There is no criteria left for us to fulfill,” Zulfaj said.

“We’re doing good as a country,” Zulfaj added, checking off a list of achievements and reforms. “What is lacking is unity from the EU. And this unity is not going to just miraculously happen if nobody looks for it, if nobody pushes it, if we are not on the agenda.”

Five EU countries — Cyprus, Greece, Romania, Slovakia and Spain — don’t recognize Kosovo’s independence, broadly due to concerns about territorial integrity and the precedent of unilateral secession. That leaves Kosovo’s EU path hostage to the bloc’s lack of consensus about its very existence.

Russia benefits: “We feel like [Kosovo] has been very much neglected,” Zulfaj said, adding that Moscow was attempting to stoke divisions and anti-EU sentiment in Kosovo. “You cannot be complacent about the region and then wonder why there is malign influence … The people there are waiting for the EU to deliver.”

DASHBOARD

POLITICO analysis of State of the Union addresses over the past decade shows how the bloc's narrative has shifted toward defense, security, energy and artificial intelligence . In 2020, the speech highlighted Green Deal plans and post-pandemic recovery programs; back in 2015, it focused on the Greek debt crisis and an upsurge in refugee arrivals in 2015.

5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

ENDGAME IN BERLIN: Hans von der Burchard runs through the scenarios facing Germany's embattled Chancellor Friedrich Merz.

MEANWHILE, IN EAST GERMANY: Center-left state premier Manuela Schwesig is close to halting the rise of the far right — but it'll come at a steep price for Merz.

SOTEU POSTMORTEM: Von der Leyen's remarks about AI showed the limits of her power ... competition chief Teresa Ribera said she's open to giving AI companies more room to cooperate on safety without running afoul of antitrust rules ... and while von der Leyen diagnosed Europe's ecological malaise , she was less forthcoming about the cure.

CEUTA CALL: The EU as a whole is threatened by the crisis in Ceuta — and should step in to clean up the mess, Spanish opposition leader Alberto Núñez Feijóo argues in an op-ed on POLITICO this morning.

ATTAL GOES FEDERAL: French presidential hopeful Gabriel Attal is expected to take aim at von der Leyen in a speech outlining his EU platform today — with a pitch for a United States of Europe, my colleague Sarah Paillou reports. (Reminder: His partner Stéphane Séjourné is one of von der Leyen's executive vice presidents.)

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Cloudy with showers in the afternoon. High 18C.

WEDDING BELLS: Our colleague Jacopo Barigazzi married his longtime partner Gaia Giorgio Fedi yesterday. Congratulations to the happy couple!

ON THE MOVE: Joaquín Noguez García has been appointed head of unit for fundamental rights, values and rule of law at the Council. He stays in the Justice and Home Affairs directorate-general, where he has spent the past seven years as adviser to the director-general.

Miia Lahti has been appointed Finland's ambassador to the EU's Political and Security Committee. She replaces Juha Ottman, who has moved to become director for the Middle East and North Africa at Finland's foreign ministry.

VOTE WITH YOUR FEET: International IDEA is hosting a conference today on democracy and the threats it faces, featuring Spanish, Ukrainian and Irish politicians and NGOs, as well as former EU commissioner Věra Jourová.

IN THE STREETS: Staying with the democracy theme, philosopher Eric Corijn is delivering a public lecture at the Vrije Universiteit Brussel at lunchtime, looking at the relationship between cities and anti-authoritarianism.

IMPERIAL LEGACY: Rosas Performance Space in Forest hosts a screening of the film “Every Contact Leaves A Trace,” described as a “criminal investigation” conducted by people who had suffered under colonialism. The film screens at 4 p.m., followed by a Q&A with its creators. [More info here](#) .

MESSING WITH YOUR MIND: An exhibition of the work of brain-bending illusion artist M.C. Escher kicks off today at Tour & Taxis in north Brussels, with more than 150 original artworks and interactive exhibitions promising a “world of the impossible.” [Tickets and details here](#) .

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz is under pressure to deliver relief on fuel prices ahead of Sunday’s crucial state election.

Paris: Rising fuel prices are also putting the French government on the defensive , while Marine Le Pen pitches a massive energy tax cut.

London: The Bank of England will announce its latest decision on interest rates , giving an indication of the economic terrain ahead of Andy Burnham’s autumn budget.

Washington: David Sacks, Donald Trump’s AI whisperer, brushed aside the mounting concerns about runaway AI as “fearmongering” in an interview at POLITICO’s Decoded summit.

Ottawa: While Mark Carney speaks to the European Parliament, Canada’s foreign minister is keeping the diplomatic push going back home , hosting rare visits by Kuwait and Singapore.

Canberra: Home Affairs Minister Tony Burke finally lays out Labor’s long-awaited migration reset today.

****Your next Playbook speaks Spanish. Madrid Playbook brings POLITICO’s original reporting, sharp analysis and essential political agenda to Spain every morning. [Learn more and sign up here](#) .****

AGENDA

— Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney addresses the European Parliament in Strasbourg at 11:30 a.m. Followed by a press conference with Parliament President Roberta Metsola. [Watch the speech here](#)

— European Council President António Costa continues his “Tour des Capitales” in Dublin, meeting Irish Taoiseach Micheál Martin and presenting the conclusions of his visits to EU capitals.

— European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and Executive Vice President Henna Virkkunen hold a press conference on the EU KIDS Act at 10 a.m. [Watch here](#) .

— Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič holds a video conference with Chinese Commerce Minister Wang Wentao.

— NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte meets British Foreign Secretary Ed Miliband and Defence Secretary Wes Streeting in the U.K.

- EU High Representative Kaja Kallas meets EBRD President Odile Renaud-Basso.
 - Executive Vice President Stéphane Séjourné meets with Croatia’s Prime Minister Andrej Plenković and Croatian authorities and industry representatives to discuss European competitiveness and single market initiatives.
 - Defence Commissioner Andrius Kubilius participates in the signing ceremony of an EU-South Korea agreement on cooperation on secure connectivity.
 - Migration Commissioner Magnus Brunner travels to Madrid to meet representatives of the Spanish government.
 - Economic Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis meets Irish Taoiseach Micheál Martin, Tánaiste and Finance Minister Simon Harris and Enterprise, Tourism and Employment Minister Peter Burke in Dublin.
- **Playbook Live is coming to Brussels and Paris next week. Following our London debut in July, join us online on Sept. 22 and 24 as our journalists bring Europe’s political power plays and France’s 2027 presidential race to the stage, alongside the people shaping them. Register here to watch Brussels Playbook Live and here to watch Playbook Paris Live.**

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Ioan-Rareş Bogdan; former MEPs Richard Ashworth and Amjad Bashir; InnoGage’s Daniel Van Lerberghe; La Maison Holistic Properties Group’s Begoña Sampedro; former Deputy General Secretary of ETUC Katja Lehto-Komulainen; former Europol chief Rob Wainwright; World Central Kitchen’s Richard Wolffe; BeBartlet’s Adrian Jofre Bosch; Matthew Boyse, former U.S. deputy assistant secretary of State for European and Eurasian affairs; Carbon Pulse’s Sara Stefanini; Narendra Modi, PM of India; Georgia Brooks, founder and CEO of The Nine and POLITICO 28 alumn.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO’s EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

A message from Altana: The rules of global trade have changed. Tariffs are tools of statecraft. Supply chains are leverage. And the old frameworks — built for a world of open markets and stable alliances — no longer hold. Policymakers need a new architecture. One that enables enforcement and trade simultaneously. One that lets governments collaborate across borders without compromising what's sovereign. Altana is that architecture. Our AI-powered network maps supply chains to the product level, verifying origin, process, and compliance before goods ever ship. Government agencies across the UK, US, Australia, and Singapore already connect through Altana to design and enforce trade and economic security policy — while businesses manage trusted trade on the same shared platform. The next era of trade won't be won by those who build the highest walls. It will be won by those who build the deepest trust. Visit altana.ai to learn how Altana can support your trade and economic security objectives .

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